



YOU ARE **20 WEEKS AND 5 DAYS**

135 days to go

YOUR BABY TODAY

The skin is less translucent now as your baby is starting to lay down fat reserves, which after the birth will help with temperature control and provide an energy reservoir for your baby to call upon when necessary.

“Your baby is becoming more responsive and aware every day as their nervous system begins to work more effectively.”

By this stage, your baby can detect a number of tastes and in a few weeks he'll start recognizing and responding to sounds. However, the nerve pathways that carry information about pain, temperature, and touch are only just starting to develop at around 20 weeks, and it will be some time before these sensations can be recognized on a conscious level.

Your baby does have reflexes from an early age—for example, from about 10 weeks he'll close his fingers if they are touched. However, reflexes only require a nerve connection to the spinal cord and do not involve the brain. For information about pain, temperature, and touch to be recognized, it must travel from your baby's body to his spinal cord and then on to the thalamus, which lies in the center of the brain. The thalamus then sends signals to the cortex, the outer surface of your baby's brain, where the stimuli can be recognized and also evoke an emotional response.

These connections are thought to function after 26 weeks of pregnancy, but it may be several weeks later before their electrical activity can be detected on an electroencephalogram (EEG). Many of these nerves require insulation around them to conduct signals effectively, and these do not develop until much later in pregnancy (see [You are 29 weeks and 2 days](#)).

ASK A MOM

This is my second baby—does it make sense to go to prenatal classes again? I think so. There were three years between my pregnancies and it helped to have a refresher course; I even found that some of the advice had changed in that time. It's also great to meet some pregnant moms again to share the experience with others.

WEARING MATERNITY SUPPORT STOCKINGS

Maternity stockings promote circulation and the return of blood back to the heart and may be recommended to prevent vein-related problems, particularly if you suffer from [varicose veins](#) or [spider veins](#).